

Password & Hash Decision Guide — From Source to Tool

Decide between identify → John or Hashcat → wordlist/mode → show → validation, including ZIP, SSH, Windows, Linux, and Kerberos-derived material.

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Usage note: This guide summarizes the decision. The John and Hashcat guides contain the detailed commands.

SOURCE

Where from?

IDENTIFY

What type?

TOOL

John / Hashcat

VERIFY

--show

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1. Before the tool: what do you have?

The source often determines the path faster than the string appearance alone.

Source	Clue	Path
Linux /etc/shadow	crypt formats such as yescrypt or \$6\$	John or Hashcat after identifying the scheme.
Windows NTLM dump	NTLM	Use the correct John/Hashcat format.
Protected ZIP	A file, not a direct text hash	zip2john → John, or an appropriate extractor.
Protected SSH private key	Key file	ssh2john → John.
Kerberos AS-REP / TGS	Specific ticket-hash format	Hashcat mode according to the exact type.
Web app / DB hash	Depends on the application	Determine the algorithm/format from the application context.

2. John or Hashcat?

Tool	Strength	Choose it when
John	Good auto-detection for some formats plus *2john converters	Excellent for ZIP/SSH/PDF and varied file-derived workflows.
Hashcat	Explicit -m plus strong GPU/attack-mode control	Excellent when the hash type is already known clearly.

3. Decision tree

FIELD GUIDE

```
[FILE such as ZIP/SSH/PDF] -> *2john -> john
[KNOWN HASH TYPE] -> find format/mode -> wordlist
[UNKNOWN HASH] -> source context -> hashid/example hashes -> verify -> crack
[CRACKED] -> --show -> validate only in lab scope
```

4. Common mistakes

- Do not guess mode/format.
- If a tool refuses the hash, the format may be wrong, a converter may be required, or the file may contain metadata/usernames in an unexpected form.
- Keep an original copy of the hash/file and use --show before restarting a long cracking job.

5. Educational workflow example

KALI TERMINAL — ZIP

```
zip2john lab.zip > lab.hash
john --wordlist=[WORDLIST] lab.hash
john --show lab.hash
```

KALI TERMINAL — Known hash

```
hashcat -m [VERIFIED_MODE] -a 0 hashes.txt [WORDLIST]
hashcat -m [VERIFIED_MODE] hashes.txt --show
```

Prepared as a quick-reference companion to the canonical Arabic guide. Use only in labs or systems you are explicitly authorized to test.

References:

Project: [Credential_Access_Cheatsheet.html](#)

[Openwall John documentation](#)

[Hashcat wiki / example hashes](#)